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OMEinsumContractionOrders: A Julia package for tensor network contraction order optimization

Jin-Guo Liu [1*], **Xuanzhao Gao** [2*], **and Richard Samuelson** [3*]

1 Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou) **2** Center of Computational Mathematics, Flatiron Institute **3** University of Florida * These authors contributed equally.

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Summary

`OMEinsumContractionOrders` (One More Einsum Contraction Orders, or OMECO) is a Julia package (Bezanson et al., 2012) that implements state-of-the-art algorithms for optimizing tensor network contraction orders. OMECO is designed to search for near-optimal contraction orders for exact tensor network contraction, and provides a comprehensive suite of optimization algorithms for tensor network contraction orders, including greedy heuristics, simulated annealing, and tree width solvers. In this paper, we present the key features of OMECO, its integration with the Julia ecosystem, and performance benchmarks.

Statement of need

A *tensor network* is a mathematical structure that represents multilinear transformations as hypergraphs. Arrays—called *tensors*—correspond to nodes, and shared indices correspond to hyperedges. To *contract* a tensor network is to evaluate the transformation on a collection of tensors by performing a sequence of pairwise bilinear operations. The computational cost—both running time and memory usage—depends critically on the order in which these operations are performed. A specific choice of ordering is called a *contraction order*, and the problem of finding an efficient ordering is called *contraction order optimization*.

Notably, this optimization task is analogous to compilation: a scheduler compiles a tensor network specification into an executable plan that can be evaluated efficiently. It is important to distinguish the *optimization time* (how long the scheduler runs) from the *contraction complexity* (the time and memory required to execute the resulting plan). An effective scheduler must balance these competing objectives—spending sufficient time to find a high-quality contraction order while remaining computationally tractable itself.

The tensor network framework has remarkable universality across diverse domains: *einsum* notation (Harris et al., 2020) in numerical computing, *factor graphs* (Bishop & Nasrabadi, 2006) in probabilistic inference, *sum-product networks* in machine learning, and *junction trees* (Villescas et al., 2023) in graphical models. Applications span quantum circuit simulation (Markov & Shi, 2008), quantum error correction (Piveteau et al., 2024), neural network compression (Qing et al., 2024), strongly correlated quantum materials (Haegeman et al., 2016), and combinatorial optimization (J.-G. Liu et al., 2023).

A contraction order can be represented as a binary tree where leaves correspond to input tensors and internal nodes represent intermediate results. The optimization objective balances multiple complexity measures through the cost function:

$$\mathcal{L} = w_{\mathsf{t}} \cdot \mathsf{tc} + w_{\mathsf{s}} \cdot \max(0, \mathsf{sc} - \mathsf{sc}_{\mathrm{target}}) + w_{\mathsf{rw}} \cdot \mathsf{rwc},$$

where w_{t}, w_{s}, and w_{rw} represent weights for time complexity (tc), space complexity (sc), and read-write complexity (rwc), respectively. In practice, memory access costs typically dominate

computational costs, motivating $w_{\mathrm{rw}} > w_{\mathrm{t}}$. The space complexity penalty activates only when $\mathrm{sc} > \mathrm{sc}_{\mathrm{target}}$, allowing unconstrained optimization when memory fits within available device capacity.

Finding the optimal contraction order—even when minimizing only time complexity—is NP-complete (Markov & Shi, 2008). However, the problem exhibits fixed-parameter tractability: for tensor networks with bounded tree-width, optimal contraction orders can be found—and the resulting contractions executed—in polynomial time. This connection to tree decomposition motivates several of OMECO's optimization strategies, which leverage graph-theoretic techniques to exploit this structure.

Algorithms for finding near-optimal contraction orders have been developed and achieve impressive scalability (Gray & Kourtis, 2021; Roa-Villescas et al., 2024), handling tensor networks with over 10^3 tensors. While the Python package `cotengra` (Gray & Kourtis, 2021) has been widely adopted in the community, achieving optimal performance across diverse problem instances—particularly when balancing solution quality against optimization time constraints—remains an open challenge.

OMECO addresses this challenge through a unified and extensible framework that integrates multiple complementary optimization strategies, including greedy heuristics, simulated annealing, and tree-width-based solvers. This comprehensive approach enables more systematic exploration of the optimization time-solution quality trade-off space. OMECO has been integrated into the `OMEinsum` package and powers several downstream applications: `Yao` (Luo et al., 2020) for quantum circuit simulation, `GenericTensorNetworks` (J.-G. Liu et al., 2023) and `TensorBranching` for combinatorial optimization, `TensorInference` (Roa-Villescas & Liu, 2023) for probabilistic inference, and `TensorQEC` for quantum error correction. This infrastructure is expected to benefit other applications requiring tree or path decomposition, such as polynomial optimization (Magron & Wang, 2021). These applications are reflected in the ecosystem built around OMECO, as illustrated in Figure 1.

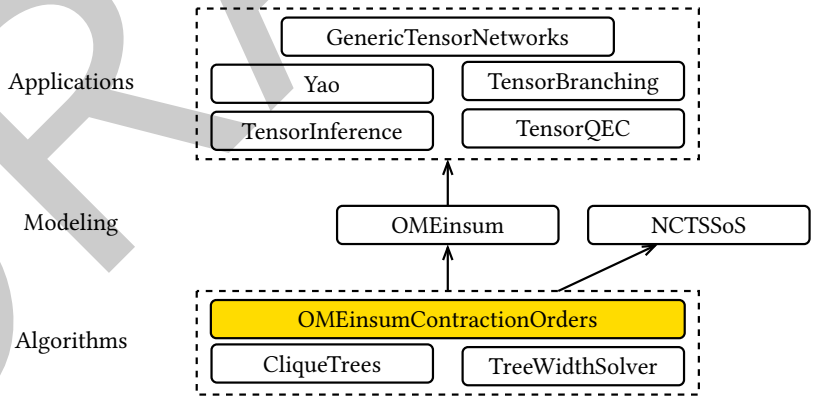

Figure 1: The ecosystem built around `OMEinsumContractionOrders` and its dependencies. OMECO serves as a core component of the tensor network contractor `OMEinsum`, which powers applications including `Yao` (quantum simulation), `TensorQEC` (quantum error correction), `TensorInference` (probabilistic inference), `GenericTensorNetworks` and `TensorBranching` (combinatorial optimization).

Features and benchmarks

The major feature of OMECO is contraction order optimization. OMECO provides several algorithms with complementary performance characteristics that can be simply called by the `optimize_code` function:

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Optimizer	Description
`GreedyMethod`	Fast greedy heuristic with modest solution quality
`TreeSA`	Reliable simulated annealing optimizer (Kalachev et al., 2021) with high-quality solutions
`PathSA`	Simulated annealing optimizer for path decomposition
`HyperND`	Nested dissection algorithm for hypergraphs, requires `KaHyPar` or `Metis`
`KaHyParBipartite`	Graph bipartition method for large tensor networks (Gray & Kourtis, 2021), requires `KaHyPar`
`SABipartite`	Simulated annealing bipartition method, pure Julia implementation
`ExactTreewidth`	Exact algorithm with exponential runtime (Bouchitté & Todinca, 2001), based on `TreeWidthSolver`
`Treewidth`	Clique tree elimination methods from `CliqueTrees` package (Samuelson & Fairbanks, 2025)

The algorithms `HyperND`, `Treewidth`, and `ExactTreewidth` are tree-width based solvers that operate on graphs. They first convert tensor networks to their line graph representation (Markov & Shi, 2008) and then find an optimized tree decomposition of the line graph using the `CliqueTrees` and `TreeWidthSolver` packages, as illustrated in Figure 1. Additionally, the `PathSA` optimizer optimizes path decomposition instead of tree decomposition. It is a variant of `TreeSA` by constraining contraction orders to path graphs, which is useful for applications requiring a linear contraction order.

These methods balance optimization time against solution quality. Figure 2 displays benchmark results for the tensor network of the Sycamore quantum circuit (Arute et al., 2019; Pan & Zhang, 2021), which is widely used as a benchmark for quantum supremacy and is believed to have an optimal space complexity of 52. The Pareto front highlights the optimal trade-off between optimization time and solution quality.

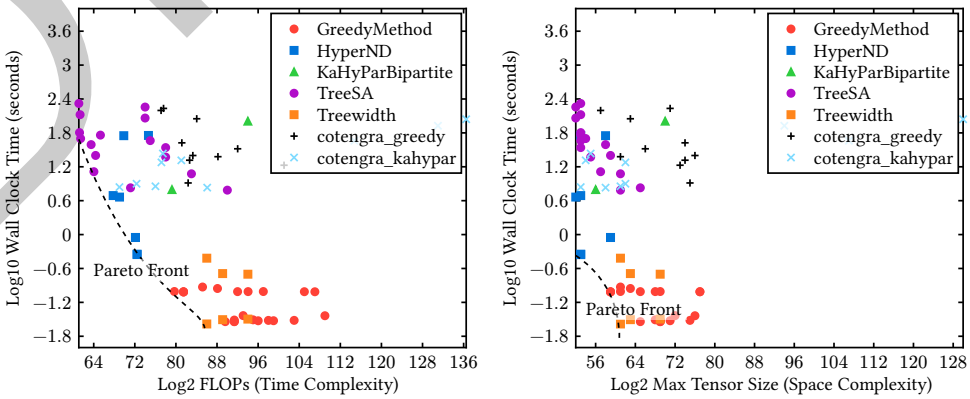

Figure 2: Time complexity (left) and space complexity (right) benchmark results for contraction order optimization on the Sycamore quantum circuit tensor network (Intel Xeon Gold 6226R CPU @ 2.90GHz, single-threaded). The x-axis shows contraction cost, y-axis shows optimization time. Each point represents a different optimizer configuration tested with varying parameters. `TreeSA` and `HyperND` achieve the lowest contraction costs, while `GreedyMethod` offers the fastest optimization time. The parameter setup for each optimizer is detailed in our benchmark repository `OMEinsumContractionOrdersBenchmark`.

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Optimizers prefixed with `cotengra_` are from the Python package cotengra (Gray & Kourtis, 2021); all others are OMECO implementations. For both optimization objectives (minimizing time and space complexity), OMECO optimizers dominate the Pareto front. Given sufficient optimization time, `TreeSA` consistently achieves the lowest time and space complexity. `GreedyMethod` and `Treewidth` (backed by minimum fill (MF) (Ng & Peyton, 2014), multiple minimum degree (MMD) (J. W. Liu, 1985), and approximate minimum fill (AMF) (Rothberg & Eisenstat, 1998)) provide the fastest optimization but yield suboptimal contraction orders, while `HyperND` offers a favorable balance between optimization time and solution quality.

More real-world examples demonstrating applications to quantum circuit simulation, combinatorial optimization, and probabilistic inference are available in the OMEinsumContractionOrdersBenchmark repository. We find that optimizer performance is highly problem-dependent, with no single algorithm dominating across all metrics and graph topologies.

Another key feature of OMECO is index slicing, a technique that trades time complexity for reduced space complexity by explicitly looping over a subset of tensor indices. OMECO provides the `slice_code` interface for this purpose, currently supporting the `TreeSASlicer` algorithm, which implements dynamic slicing based on the `TreeSA` optimizer. Figure 3 demonstrates this capability using the Sycamore quantum circuit, where slicing reduces the space complexity from 2^{52} to 2^{31}.

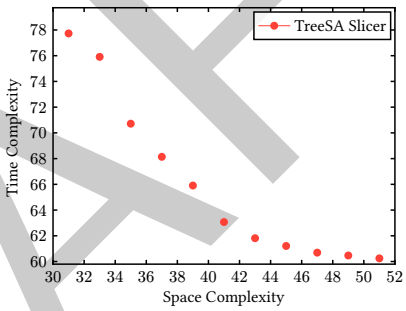

Figure 3: Trade-off between time complexity and target space complexity using `TreeSASlicer` on the Sycamore quantum circuit. The original network has a space complexity of 2^{52}.

The numerical experiments show that moderate slicing increases time complexity only slightly, while aggressive slicing can induce significant overhead. There is a critical transition point around 42 where the time complexity begins to increase significantly.

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